

Know Your Meme

Dive deep into the history of how Auto-tune elevated to the status of a meme. Explained by none other than Weird Al Yankovic - <http://youtu.be/fYzv-AVi78E>

The history of Auto-tune

You'd be surprised to know that Auto-tune was developed from technology used for seismic exploration. <http://nyr.kr/7Gtfh>

Fun with Auto-Tune

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Some of you may not be aware, but Auto-Tune is an integral part of internet culture and pop history. What started off as an automated pitch-correction and audio-processing software created by Antares Audio Technologies to help out lazy, tone deaf singers, soon became a tool for internet comedians and trolls. People started Auto-Tuning stuff all over the place – from news videos to campaign speeches to even Martin Luther King, thus placing Auto-Tune firmly in the hallowed cyber halls of internet memes! Auto-Tune garnered its share of controversy in the entertainment industry too, with some artists (the untalented ones) taking to it like fish to water and some (the more skilled ones we suppose) renouncing it, saying singers should be able to sing without artificial tuning aids. Anyway whatever the stories and back stories, we're only interested in the kind of fun you can have while playing around with Auto-Tune. In this month's Fast Track, we show you how to build a robot. Here, we'll show you how to sound like one! And a musical one at that.

Setting up Auto-Tune

Auto-Tune is a pluggin that installs itself with many sound editing and recording software. In this workshop we're going to be looking at using it with Audacity.

Must watch videos for Auto-tune in Action

Guy having fun with Auto-tune

<http://bit.ly/110RcU>

Auto-tuned news

<http://bit.ly/c0v2b>

Auto-tune episode of RJW

<http://bit.ly/aONRHR>

Best cry ever Auto-tuned

<http://bit.ly/bSqFQP>

Auto-tuned singing dog

<http://bit.ly/d6sSA7>

The first thing you need to do is make sure that you have Audacity version 1.3.12 (Beta). You can download it from <http://audacity.sourceforge.net/download/> or find it on one of the DVDs. The way that Auto-Tune is going to work is through VST effects supported by Audacity. Go to <http://www.antarestech.com/download/update.shtml> and download the VTS pluggin for Auto-Tune Evo. Once you have the pluggin you need to unzip and install it into the Audacity's pluggins folder (default is C:\Program Files\Audacity 1.3 Beta (Unicode)\Plug-Ins). The latest version of Audacity is capable of detecting pluggins on its own, but for this you need to go into Edit>Preferences>Effects and check the box for "Rescan VST Effects next time Audacity is started". Now before you restart Audacity it's recommended that you restart your system since the pluggin needs to make some changes to it. Now, when you start Audacity your trial for Auto-Tune should commence and you will have Auto-Tune in your effects dropdown list.

How to Auto-Tune

Now that you have everything set up you can get down to Auto-Tuning stuff. To begin, select a sound sample that you wish to Auto-Tune, or you can simply record your voice by clicking the red button. Make



Auto-Tune interface

a selection of the part you wish to Auto-Tune and go to Effect>Antares Audio: Auto-Tune Evo VTS. This will bring up the Auto-Tune interface.

Tweaking the Auto-Tune settings

Remember, Auto-Tune's intended use is to correct pitch and key errors i.e. automagically nudging out of tune notes to the right track. But what we're using it for is to create comical effects in our recordings. This sound signature which has now been unofficially dubbed as the Auto-Tuned sound can be achieved by playing around with some of the settings in the interface. The important settings are:



You'll find Auto-Tune under the Effect menu

Humanize which should be kept at 0, Tracking also at 0 i.e. fully relaxed so that it makes changes often, and Scale. If you have a little knowledge of music you can achieve spectacular results. These are the settings you need to tweak to make yourself sound like a Musical robot, Akon, or T-pain (of "I'm on a Boat" fame):

Key: C
Scale: Major
Retune Speed: 0
Scale detune: 4 cents, 441.0 hertz

Humanize: 0
Vibrato Settings: All 0

You can also find a preset settings file on the DVD which you can apply by clicking on Load at the top.

Once you're done playing around with the settings click ok and the effect will be applied to your sample with a few moments.

So that's it on how to Auto-Tune recorded samples. If you have a studio level sound editing software, you can set Auto-Tune to be a part of the effects chain thereby getting live effects as you speak/sing into the microphone. 